

What is Tu-B'shvat?

Tu B'Shvat, the fifteenth day of the Hebrew month of *Shevat*, is one of the four days which are characterized as *Rosh Hashanah* -- the beginning of the year, for each one of these days begins the year in respect to a specific subject.

1. The first of *Nissan* is considered to be *Rosh Hashanah* for calculating the years of the reign of the Kings of Israel. Thus, if a king was anointed in the month of *Adar*, the following month of *Nissan* would be considered to be the beginning of the second year of his reign.
2. The first of *Elul* is considered to be *Rosh Hashanah* for the tithing of animals.
3. The first of *Tishrei* is considered to be *Rosh Hashanah* for the judgment of mankind, for the calculation of the sabbatical and jubilee years, and for the calculation of *orlah* (the first three years of a fruit tree when its produce may not be eaten), and for the tithes separated from grains and vegetables.
4. *Tu b'Shevat*, the fifteenth of *Shevat*, is considered to be *Rosh Hashanah* for trees, regarding the requirement of tithing their produce. The fifteenth of *Shevat* is the boundary between one year and another regarding fruit-bearing trees. Fruits that grow after this date are considered to be produce of a new year. It is also the day on which trees are judged –how much fruit each one will produce, etc...

Observances and Customs:

On this day it is customary to partake of the fruit with which the Holy Land is praised (Deuteronomy 8:8): **Olives, dates, grapes, figs and pomegranates.**

The blessing recited on fruit is:

Transliteration: *Baruch atah A-donoy, Elo-heinu Melech Ha'Olam borei pri ha-aitz*

Translation: Blessed are You, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the tree.

- One should make an effort to eat at least one fruit which one has not eaten that entire season, and would require the blessing of *Shehecheyanu*. When eating such a fruit, the *Shehecheyanu* should be said prior to reciting the blessing of "*Haetz*."

The blessing of *Shehecheyanu*:

Transliteration: Ba-ruch A-tah Ado-nai E-lo-he-nu Me-lech Ha-olam She-heche-ya-nu Ve-ki-yi-ma-nu Ve-higi-a-nu Liz-man Ha-zeh.

Translation: Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the universe, who has granted us life, sustained us, and enabled us to reach this occasion.

Tu B'Shvat Insights

"For man is a tree of the field" (Deuteronomy 20:19).

The Tree and Man:

TREE	HUMAN
Roots	Faith- our source of nurture and perseverance.
Trunk & branches	Intellectual & Emotional achievements, the body of our spiritual lives.
Fruits	Our power of spiritual procreation – Mitzvot, and the power to influence others, to plant a seed in a fellow human being and see it sprout, grow and bear fruit.

Faith

"Teach me about Emunah – faith," a student requested of Rabbi Akiva.

Rabbi Akiva pointed to a minute plant and bid the student, "Pull up that tiny sprout." The student easily fulfilled his teacher's request.

Rabbi Akiva then pointed to a young sapling. "Pull that out," he requested. This, too, the student uprooted, with just a little more difficulty.

Now Rabbi Akiva directed his glance at a small tree. The student pulled and tugged. Eventually, with both hands on the tree and his feet firmly planted on the ground, the student was able to pull out the small tree as well.

Finally, Rabbi Akiva walked over to a full grown tree with a trunk at least 2 feet wide. "Now uproot this tree," he told his student. Try as he might, the student could not even shake a leaf on the tree let alone unearth it.

"So it is with faith," said Rabbi Akiva. "If the roots of our faith run deep, no one can uproot it. Faith is always as strong and as powerful as its roots."

A Tree's New Year Resolution

By Shlomo Yaffe

- Did I shelter the seedlings that live in my shade -- so they will grow up to be a next generation like myself?

- Did I grow towards the sun as a tree should, reaching up higher and higher towards that which I can never grasp, but which nurtures me all the same the more I strive towards it?
- Did I make sure my roots remain firmly planted in the soil that nurtures them, and did I drop my leaves there in the fall to give back life to that which sustains me?
- Did I ensure that my fruits were sweet and nourished all that came to enjoy them? Did everyone walk away from me with a smile?
- Did I bend gently in the wind, accepting what G-d sends but never breaking or giving up hope?
- Did I grow in strength and wisdom with each new ring this year?

Trees and Education

Tree	Parents
Earth	Values & Stability
Water	Humility & Purity
Sun	Living by example & love & affection
Air	Individuality & Atmosphere

“Your actions are too loud I can’t hear you”

Educate with “caution”

If a full grown tree suffers a scratch it is no great catastrophe, but woe to the tree whose original seed was scratched, for a crooked and weak tree will emerge. In our case, every small blemish or lack of nourishment to a young child results in unwanted qualities in later life. Therefore, great care must be taken to give every child a proper education which will positively affect his entire life.

A Tree's Blessing

A man wandered in the desert – weary, hungry and thirsty. He came upon a tree with sweet fruits, a pleasant shade and a stream of water flowing beneath it. He ate from its fruits, drank from its water and relaxed in its shade. As he was about to depart, a refreshed traveler, he turned to the tree and said:

"Tree, oh tree, how can I bless you? Shall I bless you that your fruits should be sweet – they are already so! Shall I bless you with a pleasant shade – you already have it! Shall I bless you that a stream of water pass beneath you – one already

does! All I can bless you with is that all the trees which are offspring of you, shall be like you." (Talmud Taanit 5B)

Fruits of our Labor

One day, as Choni was traveling along the road, he saw a man planting a carob tree. Choni asked him, "How long will it take for this tree to bear fruit?" "Seventy years," the man replied.

"Do you think that you will live another 70 years?" Choni asked. The man replied, "I found carob trees growing when I was born, because my forefathers planted them for me, so I, too, plant them for my children."

Fruit for Thought: Sometimes we don't see or know the affect that we have.

Every single Mitzvah that we do, every one of our positive actions, is a planted seed that will one day blossom and bear fruit. It may take years to see the results of our hard labor, to realize the impact of our good deeds, but they *will* come to fruition. Our deeds enrich the lives of our children and grandchildren forever. Just as those before us sowed those seeds for us, so must we resolve to sow those seeds too. We must keep planting-our children and grandchildren are depending on us.

- ❖ "When you plow and you sow, things will grow" (Hayom Yom, Cheshvan 25)
- ❖ "Those who sow in tears will reap with songs of joy. He goes along weeping, carrying the bag of seed; he will surely return with songs of joy, carrying his sheaves." (Psalms 126)

- The growth process of the bamboo plant

The Seven Fruits of the Soul

"For the L-rd your G-d is bringing you to a good land: ... A land of wheat, barley, grapes, figs and pomegranates; a land of oil-yielding olives and [dates] honey"
(Deuteronomy 8:8)

Wheat & Barley	Animalistic and G-dly Soul
Grape	Excitement
Fig	Involvement
Pomegranate	Deed/Action
Olive	Struggle
Date	Perfection

1. Wheat & Barley: Transcendence and Vitality

Each and every one of us has not one, but two souls: an animal soul, which embodies our natural, self-oriented instincts; and a G-dly soul, embodying our transcendent drives--our desire to escape the I and relate to that which is greater than ourselves.

In the Torah, wheat is regarded as the mainstay of the human diet, while barley is mentioned as a typical animal food. Some examples:

a) Isha Sotah-The wayward wife: Her offering is of barley and not of wheat. She degraded herself and behaved like an animal; let her offering therefore consist of barley, which is animal feed. (Rashi, Numbers 5:15)

b) Passover=the Omer offering of barley Shavuot=Offering of the Two showbreads

*Wheat" represents the endeavor to nourish what is distinctly human in us, to feed the divine aspirations that are the essence of our humanity. "Barley" represents the endeavor to nourish and develop our animal soul, to channel the negative traits of the animal soul into positive traits--a task no less crucial to our mission in life than the cultivation of our G-dly soul.

Wheat: Transcendence -The G-dly Soul

Barley: Vitality -The Animal Soul

Wheat and barley, the two grains among the Seven Kinds, represent the staples of our inner make-up. Following these come five fruits--appetizers and desserts on our spiritual menu--which add flavor and zest to our basic endeavor of developing our animal and G-dly souls.

2. Grape: Excitement, Joy

The defining characteristic of the grape is joy:

a) *"My wine, which makes joyous G-d and men."*
(Yotam's Parable, Judges 9:13)

b) *"And wine that gladdens man's heart"* (Psalms, 104:15)

Joy is revelation. A person ignited by joy has the same basic traits he possesses in a non-joyous state--the same knowledge and intelligence, the same loves, hates, wants and desires. But in a state of joy, everything is more pronounced: the mind is keener, the loves deeper, the hates more vivid, the desires more aggressive. Emotions that ordinarily show only a faint intimation of their true extent now come out into the open. In the words of the Talmud, "When wine enters, the concealed emerges."

Both the G-dly and the animal souls contain vast reservoirs of insight and feeling that never see the light of day because there is nothing to stimulate them. The grape represents the element of joy in our lives--the joy that unleashes these potentials and adds depth, color and intensity to everything we do.

3. Fig: Involvement

We might be doing something fully and completely; we might even be doing it joyously. But are we there? Are we involved?

The fig, the fourth of the Seven Kinds, is also the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil--the fruit which Adam and Eve tasted.

a) *Knowledge (daat) implies an intimate involvement with the thing known* (as in the verse, "And Adam knew his wife" (Genesis 4:1) (Tanya chapter 3)

Adam's fig was one of the most destructive forces in history. In its equally powerful constructive guise, the fig represents our capacity for a deep and intimate involvement in our every positive endeavor--an involvement which signifies that we are one with what we are doing.

4. Pomegranate: Deed/Action

a) *"Even the empty ones amongst you are full of good deeds as a pomegranate [is full of seeds]"* (Talmud Berachot 57a)

The pomegranate addresses the paradox of how an individual may be empty and, at the same time, be full of good deeds as a pomegranate.

The pomegranate is a highly compartmentalized fruit: each of its hundreds of seeds is wrapped in its own sac of pulp and is separated from its fellows by a tough membrane. In the same way, it is possible for a person to do good deeds--many good deeds--yet they remain isolated acts, with little or no effect on his nature and character. He may possess many virtues, but they do not become him; he may be full of good deeds, yet he remains morally and spiritually hollow.

If the fig represents our capacity for total involvement and identification with what we are doing, the pomegranate is the fig's antithesis, representing our capacity to overreach ourselves and act in a way that surpasses our internal spiritual state. It is our capacity to do and achieve things that are utterly incompatible with who and what we are at the present moment.

5. Olive: Struggle

For most of us, life is synonymous with struggle. We struggle to forge an identity under the heavy shadow of parental and peer influence; we struggle to find a partner in life, and then we struggle to preserve our marriage; we struggle to raise our children, and then struggle in our relationship with them as adults; we struggle to earn a living, and then struggle with our guilt over our good fortune; and underlying it all is the perpetual struggle between our animal and G-dly selves, between our self-oriented instincts and our aspiration to transcend the self and touch the Divine.

The olive in us is that part of ourselves that thrives on struggle, that revels in it, that would no more escape it than escape life itself. Just like an olive, say our sages, which yields its oil only when pressed, so, too, do we yield what is best in us only when pressed between the millstones of life and the counter forces of a divided self.

6. Date: Perfection, Tranquility

As the fig is countered by the pomegranate, so, too, is the olive in us contrasted by our seventh fruit, the date, which represents our capacity for peace, tranquility and perfection. While it is true that we're best when we're pressed, it is equally true that there are potentials in our soul that well forth only when we are completely at peace with ourselves--only when we have achieved a balance and harmony among the diverse components of our souls.

a) *"The tzaddik (perfectly righteous person) shall bloom as the date palm"* (Psalms 92:13)

While the olive and date describe two very different spiritual personalities, they both exist within every man. For even in the midst of our most ardent struggles, we can always find comfort and fortitude in the tranquil perfection that resides at the core of our souls. And even in our most tranquil moments, we can always find the challenge that will provoke us to yet greater achievement.